

Can We Ship This?

An honest assessment for the people who matter most

Reality check: The median indie game on Steam earns ~€4,000-€10,000 lifetime. 40-66% of Steam games fail to earn back the €100 submission fee. ~50% sell fewer than 100 copies. This document is deliberately conservative.

\$1 WHAT IT COST TO BUILD

€1,500

TOTAL CASH SPENT

8 weeks

DEVELOPMENT TIME

763

AUTOMATED TESTS

150

COPIES TO BREAK EVEN

Claude API (development sessions)	~€500
Gemini Pro (asset generation)	~€50
Historical sources (Balkan Battlegrounds)	~€100
Steam submission fee	€100
Capsule art + marketing	€500-1,000
Total	~€1,250-1,750

No loans. No investors. No money we can't afford to lose.

\$2 PRICING: €19.99

WHY €19.99

Wargamers see exceptional value (most niche wargames cost €30-50). Signals quality without pricing out the Balkan market. Room for sales: 30% off = €13.99, 50% off = €9.99. Break-even at just 150 copies.

PER SALE ECONOMICS

List price	€19.99
Steam cut (30%)	-€6.00
Regional pricing avg	-€2.00
Net to Pyrrhic (avg)	~€8-10

\$3

REVENUE SCENARIOS — THE HONEST NUMBERS



Expected value (probability-weighted): ~€50,000 Year 1. This is not a promise — it's the mathematical average across all scenarios. The most likely single outcome is the failure bucket. But the upside scenarios pull the average up.

SCENARIO	UNITS	NET REVENUE	WHAT IT MEANS
Failure	<500	<€4,000	Portfolio piece. Learning experience. Beer money.
Below median	500-2,000	€4,500-€18,000	Covers development costs. Validates the concept.
Modest hit	2,000-5,000	€20,000-€50,000	Real supplementary income. DLC worth making.
Solid success	5,000-15,000	€50,000-€150,000	Meaningful income. Consider part-time transition.
Breakout+	15,000+	€165,000+	Life-changing. Full-time indie viable.

\$4 WHY WE MIGHT BEAT THE MEDIAN

REAL ADVANTAGES

- ✓ Category monopoly — zero competition on the topic
- ✓ 20M ex-Yugoslavs with emotional connection
- ✓ AI Commander — genuine press-worthy innovation
- ✓ Deep simulation (763 tests, 90%+ historical accuracy)
- ✓ €1,500 cost basis — break-even at 150 copies
- ✓ Four separate press angles (game + AI + history + cultural)

REAL RISKS

- ✗ Solo dev, first game, no track record
- ✗ Niche of a niche (Bosnian War wargame)
- ✗ Discovery is brutal — algorithms bury unknowns
- ✗ Subject matter sensitivity — controversy likely
- ✗ Balkan market has low purchasing power
- ✗ 40% of ALL indie games fail completely

\$5 COMPARABLE GAMES — WHERE WE FIT

GAME	DEV SIZE	PRICE	EST SALES	RELEVANCE
Radio Commander	Small team	€15	~10,000	Most realistic comp — niche war, unique mechanic
Decisive Campaigns: Ardennes	Small team	€30	~12,000	Niche WWII wargame, published
Shadow Empire	1 person	€35	~30,000	Solo dev cult hit — aspirational
Unity of Command II	Small team	€30	~50,000	Ex-Yu developer! WWII strategy
This War of Mine	11 bit studios	€20	500,000+	Category creation precedent (civilian war)

Radio Commander is the realistic benchmark. Unity of Command II is the dream. This War of Mine is the lightning strike.

\$6 THE HONEST VERSION

"I'm building a strategy game about the Bosnian War. It cost us €1,500 in cash and my evenings for 8 weeks. Here's what could happen:

- 40% chance:** It makes less than €4,000. We lose nothing but my time.
- 20% chance:** It makes €4,500-€18,000. Covers costs, validates the idea.
- 20% chance:** It makes €20,000-€50,000. Real supplementary income.
- 12% chance:** It makes €50,000-€150,000. Serious money.
- 8% chance:** It breaks out bigger. But I'm not counting on it.

The break-even is 150 copies. I'll almost certainly clear that. The expected average is ~€50,000, but the most likely single outcome is much less. What I'm NOT doing: quitting my job, taking loans, or investing money we can't afford to lose. The total risk is €1,500 and my time."

\$7 WHAT MOVES THE NEEDLE

The difference between the 40% failure bucket and the 20% modest-hit bucket is **almost entirely marketing**, not game quality.

ACTION	COST	IMPACT
Steam Next Fest demo	Free	Biggest single free visibility event. 1,000-10,000 wishlists.
Dev blog (Steam News, weekly)	Free	Algorithm rewards regular updates.
Wargame YouTubers (review keys)	Free	1 well-matched creator = 500-5,000 wishlists.
3MA podcast appearance	Free	THE wargame podcast. Massive niche credibility.
Reddit/forum community	Free	r/wargames, Slitherine forums, Wargamer.com.
Balkan media outreach	Free	Cultural story: "Bosnian dev builds first BiH war game."
Professional capsule art	€200-500	Click-through rate = algorithmic promotion. #1 marketing asset.
Gameplay trailer (AI Commander)	€0-500	"Watch Mladić think." The press hook.

Total marketing budget: €200-1,500. Most high-impact activities are free.

\$8

THE AI COMMANDER — OUR SECRET WEAPON

No other strategy game has an AI opponent that actually thinks. This is the headline that gets us discovered beyond the wargame niche.

FOUR PRESS ANGLES

- Gaming:** "This wargame's opposing general actually thinks"
- Tech:** "Claude AI powers opposing commanders"
- Cultural:** "First Bosnian War strategy game"
- AI industry:** "Multi-model AI creates thinking opponents"

PLAYER TIERS

Commander (Opus)	~€13.50/game
Officer (Sonnet)	~€3.60/game
Recruit (Haiku)	~€1.10/game
Cadet (no AI)	Free

PYRRHIC GAMES

A War Without Victory — Business Model & Pricing Report
16 March 2026 — Deliberately conservative. Better surprised than disappointed.
"Another such victory and we are undone."
But at €1,500 invested, even undoing is affordable.